

Mindfulness: The Pedagogy is the Practice

Mindfulness

Teaching the Whole Student by Bringing the Whole Self to the Classroom

Dimitri Papadopoulos
Department of Mathematics

Overview

Session 1

Introduction to Mindfulness
Mindfulness as an Orientation

Session 2

Benefits of Mindfulness Mindfulness: The Pedagogy is the Practice

An Experiment

Let's sit in silence for three minutes

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- **Introductions + Discussion**

- What was that like? What did you notice?
 - Why a mindfulness workshop?
 - What does it mean, to you, to *teach the whole student* or to *bring your whole self to your teaching*?
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Mindfulness: A Very Brief Introduction

- What Mindfulness is Not
 - Mindfulness as Remembrance
 - Mindfulness a Particular Way of Paying Attention
 - Mindfulness as the Simple Act of Noticing New Things
 - Anchoring Attention
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What Mindfulness is Not

- Mindfulness is about becoming relaxed
 - It *might* be a byproduct (sometimes)
 - Mindfulness is about attaining any particular state of consciousness
 - Bliss, concentration, peace, joy, etc.
 - Mindfulness needs to be practiced under ideal conditions
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Mindfulness as Remembrance

- The Pali word most often translated as mindfulness is *sati*.
 - Memory, remembrance
 - Remembering to be present, to pay attention
 - Remembering our values and intentions
 - “Lucid awareness of the phenomenal field.” (Bodhi, 2013)
 - Waking up from autopilot or from a daydream
 - That moment of noticing that we’re lost in thought is the moment of mindfulness
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Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction

- Jon Kabat-Zinn first defined mindfulness in the context of the **Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR)** program he developed in **1979**.
 - UMASS Medical Center
 - Foundation of most clinical applications of and research on mindfulness
 - One of several mindfulness-based interventions (MBIs)
 - MBCT, ACT, DBT
 - JKZ: *awareness that arises through **paying attention, on purpose, in the present moment, non-judgmentally***
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Ellen Langer (a non-Buddhist definition)

- American psychologist and professor at Harvard University
 - Made history in 1981 as the first woman to gain tenure in the psychology department at Harvard
 - Research: **mindfulness**, the **illusion of control**, decision-making, and aging.
 - Plant study: late 1970s w/ Judith Rodin (Langer & Rodin, 1976)
 - Mindfulness: **the simple act of actively noticing new things.**
 - Mindlessness: a state of mind characterized by an **over-reliance on past categories and distinctions** (*premature cognitive commitment*)
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Seven Anchors Practice

- Practice of anchoring attention: sensations in the body, sights, sounds
 - Like a boat that has dropped anchor, we don't expect the mind to remain motionless
 - The anchor keeps the mind from wandering too far (lost at sea)
 - No expectation of perfect concentration
 - The moment we notice we're lost in thought, **that is the moment of mindfulness**
 - So long as we're **noticing** what's arising, everything is permissible as an object of meditation
 - Judgment, distraction, frustration, to-do lists, images, sounds, etc.
 - Let's try it
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Discussion

- What did you notice?
 - How did that compare to sitting in silence?
 - What do we cultivate through such a practice?
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Mindfulness as an Orientation

- Turning curiosity inward
 - Beginner's Mind
 - Coordinating intention, attention, attitude
 - Being versus having
 - (Self-)Compassion
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Turning our Curiosity Inward

- Taking the curiosity we typically point outward in exploring our respective disciplines and turning inward
 - Erich Fromm: Reason applied outward is science; reason applied inward is introspection
 - We privilege the objective over the subjective
 - * Critical subjectivity
 - **Self-knowledge** in the Socratic sense: not an autobiography but an operating manual
 - Overcoming self-deception
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Beginner's Mind

- *Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind*: “**In the beginner's mind there are many possibilities, but in the expert's there are few.**” (Suzuki, 2020)
 - Unbridled curiosity
 - Langer's definition: **the simple act of actively noticing new things.**
 - Overlaps with research on self-actualization: *continued freshness of experience*
 - Goethe: “**Every object well-contemplated opens a new organ of perception in us.**”
 - Play + Experimentation
 - We conduct experiments and observe
 - We can set up the conditions for *fun* but can't force ourselves to have fun
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Coordinating Intention, Attention, and Attitude

- **Intention**: D. H. Shapiro found that “as meditators continue to practice, their intentions shift, along a continuum from self regulation, to self exploration, and finally to self liberation.”
 - **Attitude**: Non-judgmental
 - Neither pushing away what is unpleasant nor grasping onto what is pleasant
 - Doesn't mean non-discerning
 - **Attention**: Present-moment
 - Types: focused attention, open monitoring
 - * Balancing the two
 - Husserl: “to return to things themselves.”
 - Weil: “Attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity.”
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Not a deficiency mindset

- Fromm's being-mode rather than having-mode
 - Zen: you're perfect just as you are, and you could use a little improvement
 - There's no bad meditation
 - The moment you notice you've become distracted is the moment of mindfulness
 - All objects of attention are permissible
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(Self-)Compassion

- When we start to see with greater clarity the way our mind's operate, we won't always like what we find.
 - It's easy to get frustrated by our inability to stop the proliferation of distracting thoughts
 - In practice, we cultivate this by first noticing the tendency to judge: good, bad, too distracted, too tired, too anxious, too annoyed, too impatient.
 - We notice with a greater sense of openness, and some distance: "there is distraction" or "there is impatience" or "there is annoyance"
 - **A cup of salt in a pint of water vs. a cup of salt in a reservoir**
 - Through the practice of non-judgmental observation of our minds, we start to find space
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Practice

Simple breath-focused anchoring practice into open monitoring

Discussion

- We discussed five aspects of the orientation of mindfulness
 - Turning curiosity inward
 - Beginner's Mind
 - Coordinating intention, attention, attitude
 - Being versus having
 - (Self-)Compassion
 - How do you see these overlapping with your own orientation toward teaching and working with students/colleagues?
 - How do they overlap with your conception of teaching the whole student?
 - How do they overlap with your conception of bringing your whole self to your teaching?
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Citations

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